



Apple iPhone 3G Over-hyped novelty, or a flawed jewel?

Apple's design sense has always been splendid; the iPhone 3G doesn't break conformity. The first time you look at it; you'll think iPod Touch on a high-fat diet. It's better looking than its predecessor (the iPhone 2G). The black model we received was beautifully finished; thankfully the rear resists normal smudging and scratches. It's not a very thick device but feels large to hold; although with a 3.5-inch screen this isn't exactly a design flaw. Build quality is excellent. Quality of buttons and switches on the device are top-class. Even the SIM tray fits flush; attention to detailing is very good.

The buttons on the sides, top and the headphone jack are chromed, and the black bezel and chrome trim add further visual appeal. Apple's menu system is excellent with the single *main menu* button being perfectly functional. The 3G's appeal lies in its blatantly simple and usable interface and the sheer joy and funkiness of a touch and finger swipe navigation system that works flawlessly. The proximity sensor and low-light sensor work flawlessly.

The iPhone menus work well, but the on-screen keypad is a little small and you will make a few incorrect key taps for a month or so, which won't please SMS junkies. The phones number pad is huge though; and you'd be a clod to goof up dialling numbers. SMS' sent and received to and from a single number show up as a single entry with the last

message exchanged as a preview; the rest of the messages are displayed in small green conversation boxes that become visible on selecting the relevant entry; a novel concept that takes getting used to. There is still no way to delete or select multiple messages. For some, the text entry box may also appear too small for practical use. If you try to edit a message after typing it out; the inbuilt magnifier helps as it magnifies the spot where your finger touches, but cursor navigation within the text body remains a tricky affair. You also cannot save a typed out SMS as a draft, and the inbuilt email option allows you to save multiple email IDs and password information for quick use; though the on-screen keyboard raises its ugly head again to spoil the party.

Its Safari web browser is

very basic — no support for Java or Flash. Copy/Pasting is also not supported — a serious omission. We also noticed that the touch interface works with fingers only, not a stylus or fingernails — ladies beware. If you think you can get a Bluetooth keyboard to make up for the on-screen keyboard, think again; the iPhone's Bluetooth works with headsets only — no keyboard, and no file transfers.

The bundled GPS and Google Maps work well in tandem — better than Nokia Maps. Apple's inbuilt scheduler and calendar work well; as good as any PDA. A lot of games come preinstalled, but there's no serious office application with document and spreadsheet support. Some of these applications slow down the phone — big time; though for the most part it's fairly responsive.

The iPhone is a decent phone when it comes to signal quality — it's a little behind Nokia's best phones in this regard. Voice quality is pretty good but the volume is a little low. Sadly the loudspeakers' quality is very bad — like a cheap CDMA unit — and a lot of distortion occurs when a voice call is put on loudspeaker. The headset looks like Apple's earbud headphones but incorporates a small microphone unit that is compact enough to be easily missed. Voice quality on this handsfree unit is absolutely top notch; and the volume level is fantastic.

The claimed battery talk time is ten hours; not true, we measured

this to be more like five hours.

MP3 quality is very good; no other phone comes close. It has a gorgeous screen for video. Just make sure to ditch the bundled earplugs for music. Eight or 16 GB of inbuilt storage is enough for most; if it isn't, you should remember that expansion is not an option. The camera is a mediocre 2 megapixels, and isn't this phone's forte — you can't even record video!

Sadly, the iPhone only comes as part of a service provider's scheme — you cannot buy it unless you're an Airtel or Vodafone customer. Our device was provided by Airtel and is available for Rs 31,000 and Rs 36,100. The first 500 MB of data usage from Airtel is free, after which you pay a nominal charge of 30 paisa per 50 KB.

This is a phone that is far from perfect; For the record, there are many better phones out there which offer a lot more functionality. Where Apple scores is in adding a little human touch to their device.

Specifications

3.5-inch screen, 480 x 320 pixels, 8/16 GB storage, inbuilt WiFi and A-GPS, 2 MP camera, weight — 133 g

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Web site: www.apple.co.in

Price: Rs 31,000 (8 GB),

Rs 36,100 (16 GB)

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Samsung Innov8 Somewhat Innov8ive phone from Samsung

While most of the crowds are attracted towards the likes of the HTC Touch and the all new iPhone, there are some who still truly believe in powerful phones with physical buttons. There has been some anticipation and the Samsung I8510, or the Innov8 as it is better known, is finally here.

The design looks somewhat like the Nokia's powerful N95 with a similar slider design. The slider is wobbly at times. The design isn't unconventional, but it isn't very stylish either. An array of touch-sensitive buttons line the panel below the screen. There are two dedicated buttons on this panel that make multitasking to the next and the previous running application really simple.

The operating system on this phone is the Symbian S60 3rd edition. The phone comes with a whopping 16 GB of inbuilt memory. If that isn't sufficient space for you, then a Micro SD slot is also available to expand this.

Audio quality and reception is good. Using the keypad under the slider works well although the keys themselves don't have the nicest feel to them.

The screen is good; the colours are good; so are the viewing angles and the refresh rate. This is great because the phone has video support for the commonly used DivX format. Movies run smoothly



without any signs of framing whatsoever.

One of the largest selling points of this phone has to be the 8 MP resolution camera. The inbuilt flash works alright. Image quality from the camera is not very good. The images seem artificially enhanced to look very attractive. With a smaller sensor than standard point-and-shoot cameras, it is not possible to capture great quality at 8 MP.

A basic video sequencing application comes installed

which allows you to make your own video compilation by queuing up videos and photos with transition effects in between. The audio quality of the speaker on the phone is good and there is hardly any distortion with the volume set to maximum. It must also be said that phone isn't very loud either.

As expected from any phone over Rs 15,000 or so, WiFi is present and so is GPS. The phone also comes with software — Route 66 and some other GPS tracking utilities. Google Maps is also one of the custom software installed on the phone. There are also some other software and games such as the mobile version of FIFA 2008 and a bike racer called *Asphalt 4*. The fast paced games don't run as well

as you'd like them to but they're still about playable.

The performance maybe decent but the phone gets warm when you run a few videos or play some games on it. The other problem is that playing games on the keyboard is a little difficult. You also have to get used to the touch-sensitive buttons below the screen — when you've slid your finger to select the item you want and you move the finger away to click on a button, it slides to the next item.

Overall, it's a good phone with loads of features that you might not need or use. It isn't very impressive though, especially for something that is one of the costliest phones around priced at Rs 43,250. It's nothing something that will anyone's jaw drop either. There is no doubt, that the iPhone will grab a lot more attention than the Innov8 and that is available for around Rs 31,000. The iPhone would appear to be a better buy for people just wanting a stylish phone that also happens to be very usable even though it's just a touch-phone. If you want a phone with a proper keypad, loads of features and the ability to install one of the many Symbian applications available online, then the Innov8 although expensive will fit your spot.

Specifications

2.8-inch screen, 16 GB inbuilt memory, 8 MP camera, inbuilt GPS, Symbian S60 3rd edition, 1200 mAh battery. Dimensions: 106.5 x 53.9 x 17.2 mm, Weight: 136 g

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Web site: www.samsungmobile.in

Price: Rs 43,250

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★